

GUEST COLUMN **Dr Andrew Weil**

Living better and LONGER

How can you maximise happiness, no matter how old you are? Don't fight old age, just embrace it. Age healthily as you go through life.

Modern societies are programmed to see ageing as a catastrophe. But ageing is a universal process. Animals age, plants age, mountains age, stars age. If ageing is written into the laws of the universe, then resisting it would be to put oneself into a wrong relationship with nature. The key lies in accepting the ageing process and learning the principles of lifestyle. I call it 'healthy ageing': maintaining health as you go through life. The scientific community focuses on the 'why' of ageing. For me, the moot question is 'how': how we can shorten our period of decline, so that at any age we have the energy and the capacity to enjoy life? It is very helpful to seek out people who are examples of healthy ageing and see what they have to teach us.

Ageing and longevity are partly determined by genes and partly by lifestyle. Acceptance of the ageing process really means learning the principles of lifestyle—eating right, sleeping right, moving right, reducing stress, maintaining good relations and playfulness, keeping the mind active, using the best of natural and preventive methods in everyday life.

Make gradual changes in lifestyle. Do things in little steps and build on them. A common problem is that people make lofty resolutions, try it for a while and then give up. But if you work to adjust your lifestyle gradually—walking a few extra miles, making an effort to cook a meal yourself—you notice positive

changes, you start feeling better and the motivation grows.

There are certain things that better with age—whiskey, wine, cheese, trees, violins, antiques. If you look at whiskey, age smooths out its rawness, adds depth and complexity, adds flavours, and concentrates what's desirable. At the same time, there is the evaporation of what is less consequential. I think, it's fairly easy to see analogies in human life. Ageing can increase value by concentrating what is most worthy and by allowing what's inconsequential to dissipate.

As people get older, diseases become more frequent. But does getting old necessarily mean getting sick? The answer clearly is 'no'. It is possible to delay the onset of age-related diseases. So the point is to live long and well and then have a rapid drop-off at the end. The goal for me is to work toward 'compression of morbidity'—a lovely term where morbidity has the medical meaning of sickness.

A wonderful story did the rounds in the US some months ago. A Los Angeles transit road worker had worked at the job every day until he was 101. On his 101st birthday, his co-workers and friends gave a huge party. The next day, he died. That is compression of morbidity. And that is what I urge you all to work toward.

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